# THE ROLE OF MIDDLE POWERS

in (re)balancing
the global governance system &
reviving multilateralism and the UN

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# THE NEW GEOPOLITICAL CONTEXT

**The global governance system under strain for several reasons:**

- Rise of China and BRICS, and relative decline of the US and the West;
- Resurgence of nationalism & populism in many countries, including the US;
- Capture of politics by economic interests / oligarchs;
- Lack of enlightened leadership and vision in most countries and international organisations;
- “Systemically important” wars that can blow up the system / cause WWIII;
- UN Security Council paralysed by the veto power, especially when it comes to conflicts involving the major powers or their direct proxies;
- Existing governance structures ill-equipped to address global challenges such as climate change, pandemics, and cyber threats that require collective action and pooling of resources.

*In this context, there is a growing recognition that the global governance system needs to be rebalanced to reflect the realities of the 21st century. “Middle powers”, with their commitment to multilateralism and their ability to bridge divides, are seen as key players in this process*.

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# WHO ARE THE "MIDDLE POWERS"?

- States that occupy a middle ground in the international system, neither dominating it nor being dominated by others.
- Relative economic strength, diplomatic influence, and commitment to multilateralism.
- States that often punch above their weight in international affairs, leveraging their diplomatic skills, soft power, and commitment to international norms to influence global governance.
- Otherwise, a diverse group in terms of geographic location, economic development, and political systems.

# Certainly not the US, China and Russia, probably not India either

| | |
|---|---|
| ***The Americas*** | Brazil, Mexico, Chile, Colombia?, Barbados?, Jamaica? (CariCom?), Canada? (Andean Community?) |
| ***Africa*** | South Africa, Nigeria?, Ghana?, Senegal, Kenya, AU? |
| ***Middle East*** | Saudi Arabia?, UAE?, Egypt?, Morocco? |
| ***Asia & Pacific*** | Indonesia, Malaysia?, (ASEAN?), Japan, ROK, Singapore? (Small States group?), Australia, New Zealand?, Pacific Islands Forum?, AOSIS? |
| ***Europe*** | Germany, Italy, Spain, one or more Nordics?, Tûrkiye? (EU?) |

CRITERIA

- *Democracy / good governance domestically and good global citizenship / abiding by treaties internationally*
- *Relative weight of wealth, population and diplomatic capacity (e.g. different cases like Singapore, Norway, Indonesia, Brazil)*
- *No nuclear weapons and no active wars*
- *Constraints due to participation in G7, BRICS, NAM, G77, G20, NATO, etc.?*

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# The Role of Middle Powers in Rebalancing Global Governance

- Mediators and bridge-builders in international negotiations within and outside the UN (see also Nordics, NAM and others in the past);
- Preventive action to avoid the involvement of big powers in regional conflicts;
- Advancing culture of peace, pushing for nuclear and conventional disarmament;
- Rethinking the economy and reallocation of resources for SDGs and resilience for all;
- Support for greater transparency and accountability by multilateral institutions;
- Concrete proposals for improving the effectiveness of international institutions through reform;
- Respect for international law in own affairs and as far as others may be concerned;
- Leading by example in areas like climate action, pandemic preparedness, self-sufficiency/resilience.

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# TOOLS AT THE DISPOSAL OF MIDDLE POWERS

**“What cards do middle powers have?”,**
**as US President Trump might ask…**

- UNGA majority
(depending on middle power definition, indirectly if not directly);

- E10 UN Security Council majority and collective veto
(again depending on definition);

- Moral authority, including domestic stability and legitimacy;

- Important / catalytic “seed money” for initiatives of various kinds;

- Working with the UN Secretary-General (?);

- Cutting across North and South;

- Cutting across G7, G20, G77 and BRICS;

- Working with civil society and other non-state actors

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# What's in it for the middle powers themselves?

- Leveraging institutional power to strengthen their own position and repel pressures from the big powers.
- Priority in the allocation of limited influential positions like UN Security Council membership, senior UN Secretariat positions, etc.
- International recognition that creates a positive approach to the said country, its products and services.
- International recognition and prestige that can be translated into votes in national elections.

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# Challenges and Limitations

- Lack of resources and capabilities, especially vis-à-vis major powers;

- Resistance and threats / constraints imposed by major powers;

- International bureaucracies used to “playing” with major powers;

- Domestic backlash and opposition to external focus of government;

- Inconsistencies between words and deeds on critical issues;

- Several middle powers together – unity increases influence;

- Membership in and mobilization of institutions at various levels,

from the global to the regional, sub-regional, national and local.

# Some closing thoughts

- Institutionalisation of the role of middle powers, e.g. through new UN Security Council membership category? (but some still want permanent seats…)

- Formal or informal “Council of Middle Powers” for coordination?

- Which country/ies and leader/s will take the initiative?

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# THANK YOU!

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